been located offshore, which seem to confirm old stories of the city being overwhelmed by some natural disaster, possibly a tsunami such as the one that wreaked such havoc along this same coast in 2004.

Being sited on the coast beside the estuary of the Cauvery River meant that Kaveripattinam was well placed to take advantage of the increased traffic between Lanka and the mainland that began in Ashoka's time in the third century BCE, so much so that it expanded into an important trade emporium known to Pliny the Elder as 'Khaberis'. One of the poems in the Tamil *Purananuru* describes how even the greatest ships could enter its port without having to lower their sails, how they poured precious cargo from overseas on to the beach, and how the merchants' mansions in the city were so tall that the upper floors could only be reached by ladders. The city was further said to be divided into two districts, with a docks and warehouse area beside the sea inhabited by shipbuilders, fisherfolk and foreign traders, and a city proper further inland where the nobility, the wealthy and the intellectuals lived.

The natural disaster that overwhelmed Kaveripattinam probably occurred in the third century CE, after which the sea-trade switched to the port of Nagapattinam further down the coast, marked as 'Patinae' on the *Tabula Peutingeriana* map. Nagapattinam has a starring role in the Buddhist epic *Manimekalai*, composed by a Buddhist poet named Seethalai Saathanar towards the end of the fifth century CE and set in what was then a busy and prosperous sea-port, thronging with foreign merchants from afar speaking different languages, and ships unloading cargoes of fine horses from Arabia, gold from the northern sea and coral from the western sea. This is where the poem's beautiful heroine Manimekalai, after much personal suffering, comes looking for answers from the competing philosophies of Hinduism, Jainism, Ajivikism and Carvakism before becoming a Buddhist nun. The first modern